

A 2D DUEL SAGA · ANDROID & WEB

ASHBORN

The Last Vigil

Die. Wake. Hold the vigil again.

▶ PLAY FREE: EMBERMAK.GITHUB.IO/ASHBORN-2D/PLAY

KEI CHEONG MAI

embermak.github.io/ashborn-2d

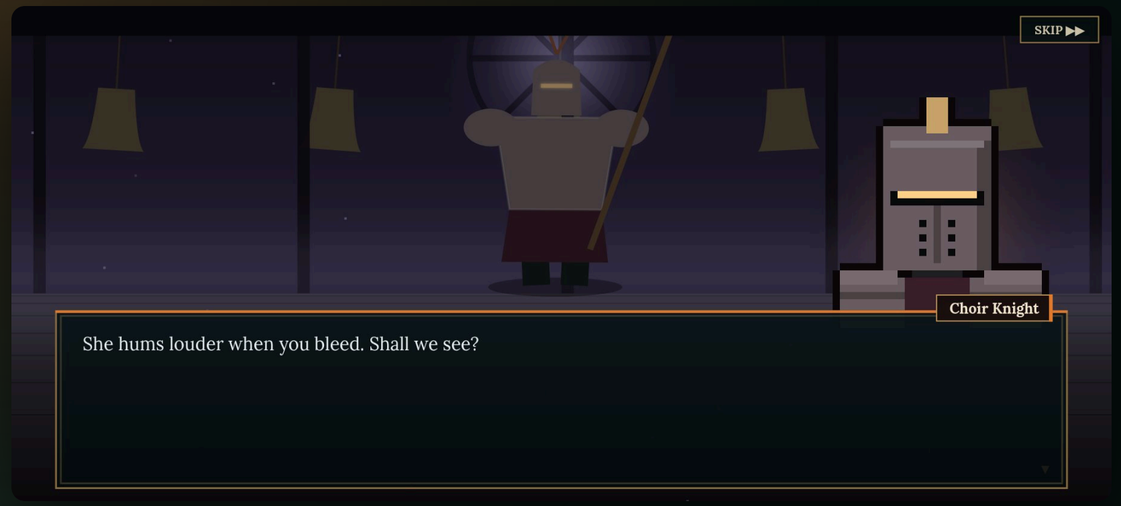
THE PREMISE

Die. Wake. Hold the vigil again.

Vael is a grey coast of salt marsh and broken causeways. On a tidal island stands the Spire of Morrow, and on its throne sits Aurec, the Ember King, who has ruled for nine hundred years.

You are Wren, a knight of the Thorne line, and you do not stay dead. Every fall adds one to the Vigil counter. You wake at the drowned cathedral with your gear intact, and you walk the causeway again.

Part Two, *The Quench*, asks what the rebirths really are: a lullaby hidden in eight places, a Kiln that printed thirty-three of you, and a choice at the end that splits the story in two.



A FULL GAME IN ABOUT 2 MB

What's inside

12	45	74	5	2	2.3
Chapters	Enemies	Pieces of gear	Gear slots	Endings	MB APK

Directional parry

Every enemy telegraphs a swing with a glowing arrow. Swipe along it to parry. A timing ring shrinks onto the arrow and grades you Parry, Great or Perfect.

Rebirth, not game over

Death adds to the Vigil counter and sends you back to the cathedral with your gear. Losing is part of the story.

Gear that changes your silhouette

Weapons, armour, shields, helms and rings across 5 slots, with drops, a shop, rarity colours and stat-delta comparisons.

REAL GAMEPLAY

FROM THE DUEL ITSELF



The Tide Warden winds up. The arrow tells you where to swipe.



Unblockable: no parry, only a dodge.



Equipment: five slots that change both stats and silhouette.



The chapter map across the causeway.

I

The cathedral I could not ship

`Unity 6 · Soft-lock`

Problem. ASHBORN began as a 3D, Infinity Blade-style duel in Unity 6. The very first phone build looked fine for exactly one hit. Then the game slowed to about 2% speed and never came back. My hit-stop effect froze time on impact and was supposed to release it, but the timer releasing it ran on scaled time, which I had just set to almost zero. The game was waiting for a clock it had stopped.

Fix. I rewrote hit-stop to count down in real, unscaled time, and added a watchdog that forces time back to normal if anything ever holds it too long. Lesson one: every effect that pauses the world needs a guaranteed way out.

II

Moving to Unreal Engine 5

`Live Coding · C2487 · C2664`

Problem. I wanted real lighting, so I ported the duel to Unreal Engine 5. Builds refused to start because Live Coding in an open editor locked the binaries. Then the C++ compiler threw C2487 and C2664 errors at me, a wrong export macro on a class member and a type mismatch in a function call, buried in engine headers I had never read.

Fix. I learnt to close the editor or disable Live Coding before every command-line build, and fixed the declarations one error at a time until the module compiled clean. Slow, but every fix taught me how the engine is actually put together.

III

219 MB TO UNDER 95 MB

`Shipping config · llvm-strip · 512 px textures`

Problem. The first Android APK was 219 MB. For a single-arena duel that is not a game, it is a download nobody finishes. Too big even to upload to my own drive for testing.

Fix. I switched to a Shipping configuration, stripped about 125 MB of debug symbols from the native library with llvm-strip, then re-aligned and re-signed the APK by hand. I disabled every engine plugin the game did not use and capped Android textures at 512 px. It came out under 95 MB.

IV

A FROZEN SCREEN AND AN INVISIBLE BOSS

`Skeletal-mesh flag · animation wiring`

Problem. The first phone test showed a frozen arena and an empty space where the boss should be. The health bars still moved when I swiped, which was the clue: the game was running, but nothing was visible or animated.

Fix. The boss material was missing the “used with skeletal mesh” flag, so mobile could not render it at all. And my hits were landing in code but were never wired to any animation. I fixed both, and the duel came alive.

V

The 2D vs 3D dilemma

`Fun vs fidelity`

Problem. Even working, the 3D build felt like a tech demo. To unwind, I rebuilt the same idea in 2D, in the browser, in a few days. My testers preferred it. That hurt a little, because 3D is where my ambition lives.

Fix. So I listened. I took the 2D version all the way: 12 chapters, 45 enemies, 74 pieces of gear and a rebirth story with two endings, in about 2 MB. 3D is not finished for me. But I now prove the fun small first, then scale it.

VI

Making it feel alive

`SF2-inspired animation · haptics · lean wrapper`

Problem. Testers said the characters felt static. I studied Shadow Fight 2 and wrote a procedural animation pass: breathing stances, weight shifts, wind-ups, lunges, recoil, blade trails and enemies that topple when they fall.

Fix. Then I dropped Capacitor for a lean WebView wrapper that my own build kit compiles without the Android SDK, and added native haptics through a JS bridge with around 30 patterns, a parry timing ring, three parry tiers, slow-motion on a perfect parry and counters.

WHAT I LEARNT

Lessons I am keeping

Fun beats fidelity

Nobody mentioned polygon counts. People talked about the moment a parry lands right on time.

Constraints are a design tool

Keeping the whole game around 2 MB forced every system to earn its place.

Every pause needs an exit

The 2% soft-lock taught me to build watchdogs into anything that touches time.

Ship to a real phone, early

Each APK on a real device taught me something no design doc could.

Next: more small, lightweight phone games that are genuinely fun. Quick to download, easy to pick up, hard to put down.

PLAY IT NOW

ASHBORN

Showcase & dev story	EMBERMAK.GITHUB.IO/ASHBORN-2D
Play in browser	EMBERMAK.GITHUB.IO/ASHBORN-2D/PLAY
Android APK · 2.3 MB	EMBERMAK.GITHUB.IO/ASHBORN-2D/ASHBORN-V2.0.1.APK

> An experimental project, not launching on the stores. Curious about the source code or want to collaborate? Message me on LinkedIn or email maikeicheong@gmail.com.